pandemic. Members in the NTF ranged from celebrated clinicians such as Dr Guleria and epidemiologists such as Dr Raman Gangakhedkar to top-ranking leadership from the National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases, the Public Health Foundation of India, the WHO, the National Institute of Epidemiology, the National Centre for Disease Control and the Enterovirus Research Centre, alongside several scientists from the ICMR system. The NTF looked at downstream research, seeking solutions to COVID-19-related clinical epidemiology issues such as how the disease was spreading and establishing a clinical registry on COVID-19. The NTF also deliberated upon and issued guidelines on testing criteria which would include advice on who would need to be tested and when it would be appropriate to use RT-PCR versus antigen and antibody tests. The group also considered emerging treatments by looking at all the available evidence from global scientific papers—peer reviewed as well as unpublished, after which it would make a decision on whether that particular treatment protocol should be used and under what caveats, i.e., the considerations to be made for people with comorbidities, dosages to be used for varying levels of the infection and such. It is in the NTF that the need to lock down the country was first discussed. The prime minister stayed on top of the information relayed by the scientists in the NTF and it was on their recommendation that he decided to lock down the country.

Closing the chain of hassle-free communication, the empowered groups which were to be created after the prime minister’s instructions following the 4 March meeting in the PMO were now in place. Eleven empowered groups would be formed to begin with. Each group would consist of experts in the subject area of the group, senior bureaucrats from ministries which would be needed in order to achieve the objectives set forth by that particular group as well as one senior official from the PMO. The groups would not have a chairperson or a leader, but a convener instead, so as to allow senior forces across spectrums to put forth their ideas equivocally, without a clash of egos. Although the official order from the Ministry of Home Affairs was yet to come, the groups had not only been constituted but had also begun to conduct meetings on a daily basis.

The R&D Task Force for COVID-19 Research and NTF would outline policy, evidence-based practices and administrative requirement for capacity building. These decisions would then trickle down to the specific empowered group which would then find a way to implement the Task